

Education IIT ACHIEVERS

would be making merry outside, there would often be no electricity, but Nagendra was not deterred. His father works in Delhi, earning Rs 10,000 a month. Since his father could not visit Nagendra frequently, it was left to mother Sonmati Devi to send him Rs 2,000 every month that the two brothers needed in Patna. Nagendra, who had to cook himself, often skipped a meal or had "anything to save time" just before the examination. The dark circles around his eyes bear testimony to this, though Nagendra now is all smiles.

Yet another success story is that of 18-year-old Aditya Kumar Mehta. His father, Vijay, who runs a small shop in Patna's Kankarbagh locality earns Rs 5,000 a month. But Mehta kept his three sons away from the shop despite working without a



SUSHANT GAURAV, 17

OBC RANK 1,031

The son of a farmer, Sushant stayed in a rented flat shared by five others in Patna for his IIT preparations. Having enrolled in Anand's Super 30, a coaching institute, he cracked the exam and now hopes to fulfil his dream of making it big.



ADITYA KUMAR MEHTA, 18

OBC RANK 918

His father did not allow him to work in his small shop that generates an income of Rs 5,000 a month. "There was an unwritten rule in my home. We had to save money for studies," says Mehta.



NAGENDRA RAM, 18

SC RANK 424

Social and economic conditions never held him back. He qualified for the exam while sharing a 10x10 room at a student lodge in Patna where water and electricity were luxuries. His father, employed in Delhi, makes Rs 10,000 a month.



helper. Aditya stays in a three-room ancestral house where the top floor was reserved for the three brothers to study. "There was an unwritten rule in my home. We had to save money for studies. Everyone cut down on expenses." Everyday, Aditya would wake up at 3 a.m. to study 14 hours a day. He made it to the IIT in his second attempt with a rank of 918 in the OBC category. "I am very happy that my boys have remained focused and made me proud," says Anand, who coached all the boys and is a noted mathematician in Patna. Anand, who enjoys almost cult status among IIT aspirants in Bihar, has developed a special simulated programme with two characters—Bholu and Rickey—and installed it in the classroom to keep the students fully charged. Bholu is a poor child and Rickey has everything, including a mobile phone and speed bike. When it comes to studies, however, Bholu emerges the winner. The Bholu and Rickey story, which Anand shows while taking the mathematics class, keeps many economically disadvantaged teenagers motivated. "One hundred and eighty-two poor candidates have qualified during the last seven years," he says with obvious pride.

This is the other India, which is clearly willing to suffer and forego its today for a better tomorrow. Perhaps nowhere else is the drive among the deprived as fierce as in Bihar, India's much-reviled backward state, where the gap between the haves and the have-nots is as wide as the angry Kosi river during the floods. ■